

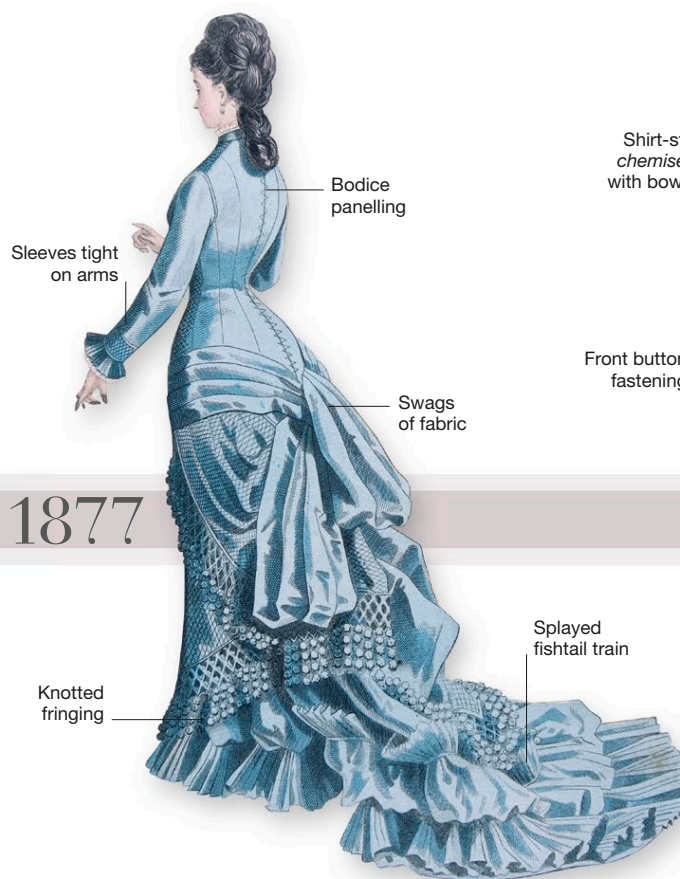
1870–1879

SOFT BUSTLES AND FISHTAILS

Fashions by the 1870s were softer and more delicate, with pastel colouring and frivolous trimmings and decoration. Bodice necklines were square, with exposed décolleté for evening. Dresses had three-quarter-length sleeves with lace cuffs, or could be sleeveless for evening wear. Aided by the sewing machine (now becoming a desirable acquisition for home use), fabric was draped and layered around the hips, creating an overskirt with apron and panniers that was supported in the small of the back by a straw or horsehair understructure, called a soft bustle. By 1875 colours were deeper, a more streamlined shape was emerging, with a smoothly fitted bodice, and the waist and hips were more defined. By 1876 dresses were shaped in a Princess line (with an all-in-one princess petticoat), often with a *cuirasse* overbodice. The upper fullness of earlier skirts had moved lower at the back, forming a fishtail train that was delightful to look at but complex to create and needed skill to manage.

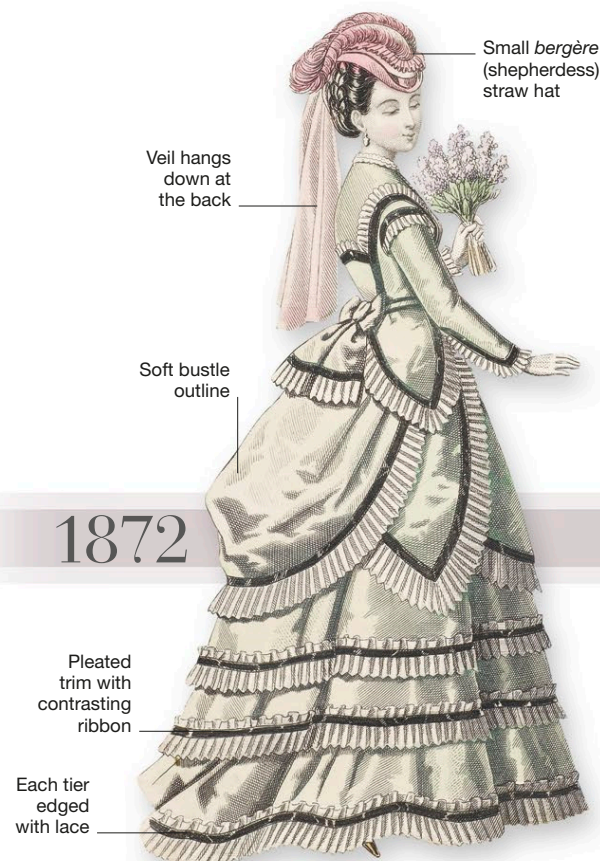
SOFT BUSTLES

To support the fullness at the top of the skirt at the back, a framework known as a soft bustle was worn. This could be made from a variety of materials, including meshed horsehair, wadding, and straw, or even improvised with scrunched-up newspaper. The example shown comprises covered watchspring steel, half hoop cording for the lower skirt, moire fabric, and a wavy braided outline along the hem. It fastens at the front of the body with buttons.



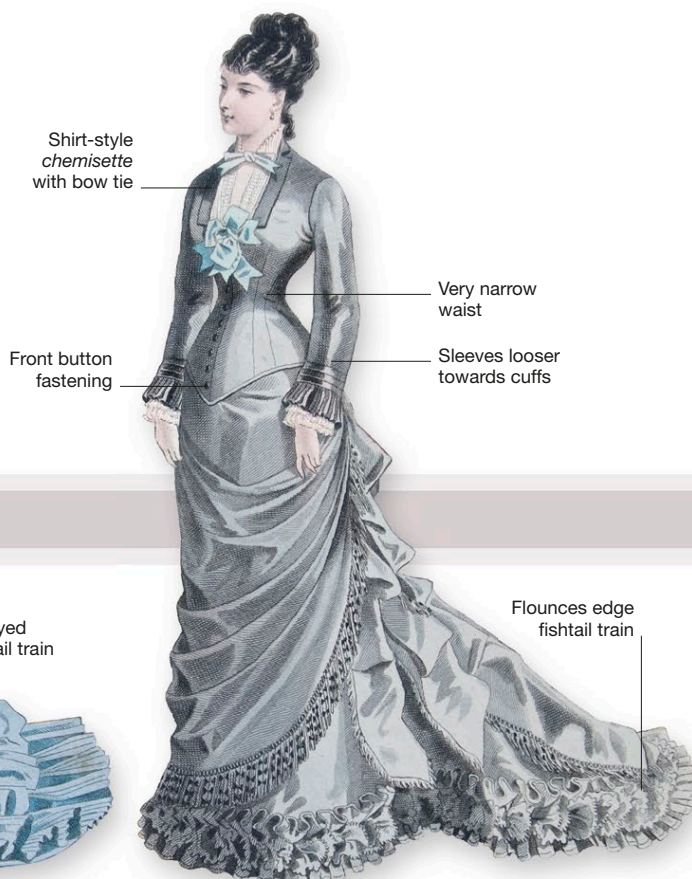
1877

Fishtail train This skirt has copious drapery, which would have hampered movement. The train would swish from side to side as the wearer walked and turned. A ribbon on the train's end could be attached to the wrist to lift the fabric for ease of manoeuvre.



1872

Wedding dress This triple-tiered main skirt is overlaid with 1770s-style polonaise overskirts, with each layer outlined in a dark trim. The *bergère* straw hat is perched jauntily on hair – real or false – that is piled high on the crown.



Cuirasse bodice The *cuirasse* (from the French for armour) bodice helped create a small waist. It was aided underneath by a princess petticoat and back-laced corset, which by now had steels and a front-opening spoonbill busk.